

SUMPTUARY LAWS & FASHION ACROSS CIVILIZATIONS

§ *Ancient Rome*

§ *Japan & China*

§ *Pre-Colombian America*

§ *Africa*

These were rules that controlled how people dressed ;Mainly about limiting luxury and showing social rank.

These laws dictated what people would wear based on their:

- o Social status*
 - o Ranks*
 - o Occupation*
 - o Morality*
- o Political control*
- o Cultural identity*

v ANCIENT ROME

Romans used clothing laws to control luxury

- ✓ *Lex Oppia (215 BC) limited women's jewelry and colorful clothing*
- ✓ *Purple dye was reserved for the elite*
- ✓ *Laws were meant to keep social order during hard times*
- ✓ *Lex Julia (18 BC) prohibited some garments like silk clothing for Roman women*
- ✓ *Only the wealthy could wear Tyrian purple*
- ✓ *Limits on gold jewelry for women*
- ✓ *Clothing showed status more than style.*



Medieval Period

- ✓ When talking of Medieval period we simply refer to the middle ages the time from 5th to the 15th century AD, while ancient Rome flourished from the 8th century BC to the 5th century AD.
- ✓ **England's 1363 sumptuary law**; dictated clothing styles and fabrics based on social status, from peasants to nobility
- ✓ **France's 1294 sumptuary law**; prohibited certain fabrics like silk and velvet for commoners.



v CHINA

- ✓ In the Ming Dynasty of China (1368-1644), Sumptuary laws were implemented to protect the structure of Confucian society.
- ✓ People were instructed on what to wear depending on their social standing, making a direct connection between one's clothing and their social status.
- ✓ The Emperor was the only one allowed to wear the yellow dragon robe and the officials wore rank badges with certain animals or birds to show their rank. Commoners, even the well-to-do merchants, were only allowed to wear muted colors and coarse, cheap fabrics like hemp.
- ✓ The laws also regulated specific things like headwear and the cut of robes, differentiating the scholar-officials from the commoners.
- ✓ Central to the laws was the prohibition of so-called "barbarian clothing," an effort to remove remnants of the Yuan Dynasty Mongol Rule and re-assert Han Chinese



v

AFRICA

- ✓ ANCIENT EGYPT ROYALTY Gold jewellery and embellished sheets **ROYAL PHARAOHS/ PRIESTS** Priests were the only one with their exclusive symbolized fabrics **COMMONERS** Only able to wear simple linen with no decorative features
- ✓ WEST AFRICAN YORUBA AND HAUSA KINGS AND CHIEFS Kings and chiefs were the only one that wore also oke, embroidered robes and crowns **BEADED CROWNS** ADE Only kings could wear it **NOBLES WORE** It was acceptable to wear the agbada, outside the ones that were more simple, along with the commoners cotton attire.
- ✓ EAST AFRICA (ETHIOPIA) CLOTHES OF SPIRITUAL LEADERS AND THE ROYALTY Tend to their rasa, shamma robes having embroidered ends for the sacred. The leaders who have more white and gold over other commoners fancier patterns **MORE SIMPLER CLOTH COMMONERS LOW CLASS**
- ✓ SOUTHERN AFRICA ZULU KINGDOM CLAN CLOTHES Worn by the men of the clan. ANCIENT EGYPT WARRIORS Leopard skins were worn from the hunts such as the ones from the leopard **LEOPARD SKINS** HIGH RANKED WARRIORS AND ROYALTY CLOTH CLOTHING CLOTHING SHOWED SIGNED OUT AGE ROLES YOUNG MEN AND MARRIED MEN CLOTH Clothing of the clan.



Pharaoh.



Ethiopia

Hausa kings {Mansa Musa}

PRE-COLOMBIAN AMERICA

- ✓ In **Aztec Empire**, the only people who were allowed to wear cotton were the nobles, while the commoners were mostly allowed to wear maguey fibres. For the elites, bright colors, shell jewelry, and turquoise were meant for them; Eagle and Jaguar warrior suits were restricted to decorated soldiers. High status was signaled by long-length capes.
- ✓ **Maya Civilization**, Elites' symbols linked to divine power were the feathered headdresses. Nobles wore jade jewelry due to spiritual significance. Lineage or political rank was represented by embroidered patterns therefor, simple woven garments were worn by commoners.
- ✓ **Inca Empire**, Fine qompi cloth made by adlas was only worn by nobles. The Sapa Inca wore unique gold feathers and the royal red fringe. Professions and class wearers were indicated/represented by colors and motifs. Violating dress codes was considered a serious offense.
- ✓ **North American Civilizations** Feather capes, shell beads, and copper plates were used by Mississippian elites. Clan, spiritual, and social roles were indicated by clothing.



feathered headdresses



jade jewelry



maguey fibres



qompi cloth

v **PURPOSES & IMPACT OF THESE LAWS**

➤ *The main role/ purpose of these laws were:*

§ *TO maintain cultural and spiritual order.*

§ *TO Show military rank or lineage.*

§ *TO reinforce power of rulers.*

§ *TO distinguish nobility from commoners.*

➤ *Impact on Fashion*

✓ *Clothing materials signaled access to resources .*

✓ *Many traditional designs still reflect ancient hierarchies today .*

✓ *Fashion was a tool of political control .*

✓ *Identity and social structure were shaped by dress.*

v **CONCLUSION:**

q *There are several law orders in the sumptuary laws aimed social order, and the laws created desire in people to display their social order which in a way created fashion to facilitate the display of social status.*